

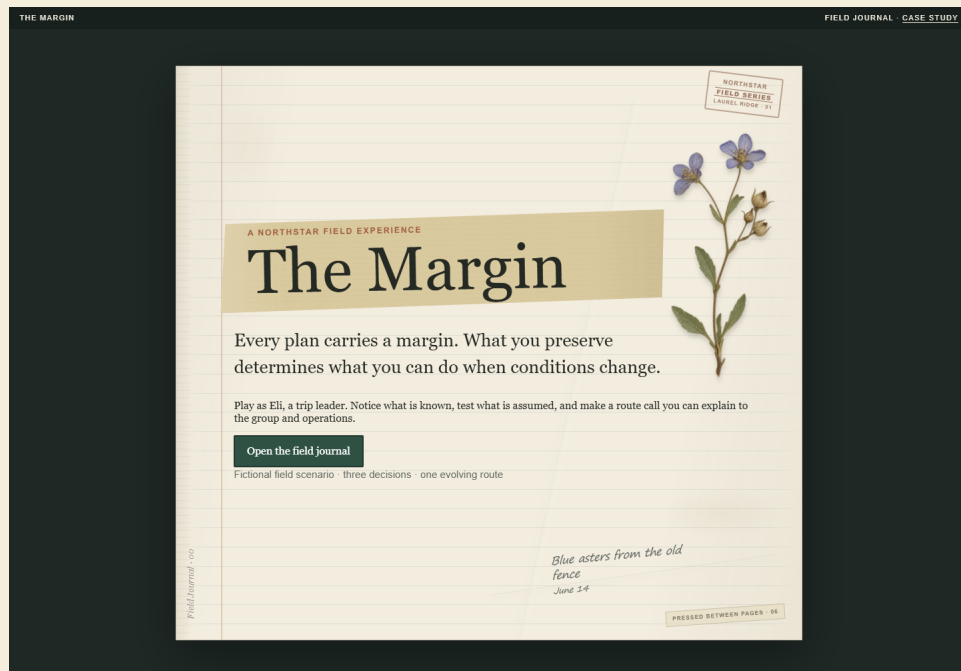
THE MARGIN

Designing judgment under ambiguity

An interactive field journal designed to help early-career professionals practice calibrated autonomy: deciding when to proceed, investigate, modify, or escalate as conditions change.

Role: Learning Experience Designer | Audience: Early-career professionals

Format: Interactive scenario prototype | Setting: Fictional Northstar Outdoor Experiences



The field journal frames the task: notice what is known, test assumptions, and make an explainable route call.

The challenge

A reasonable decision can become unreasonable without any single dramatic warning. A late departure, changing weather, and a participant's increasing knee discomfort may each seem manageable. Together, they can leave a trip leader with fewer safe options and less time to respond.

Northstar's fictional performance problem is broader than missing knowledge. Rapid growth, informal shadowing, fragmented information, and unclear decision boundaries make independent judgment harder. The design therefore starts with behavior and operating conditions, rather than assuming a course will solve everything. Clearer authority, shared updates, and practical field support would also be needed.

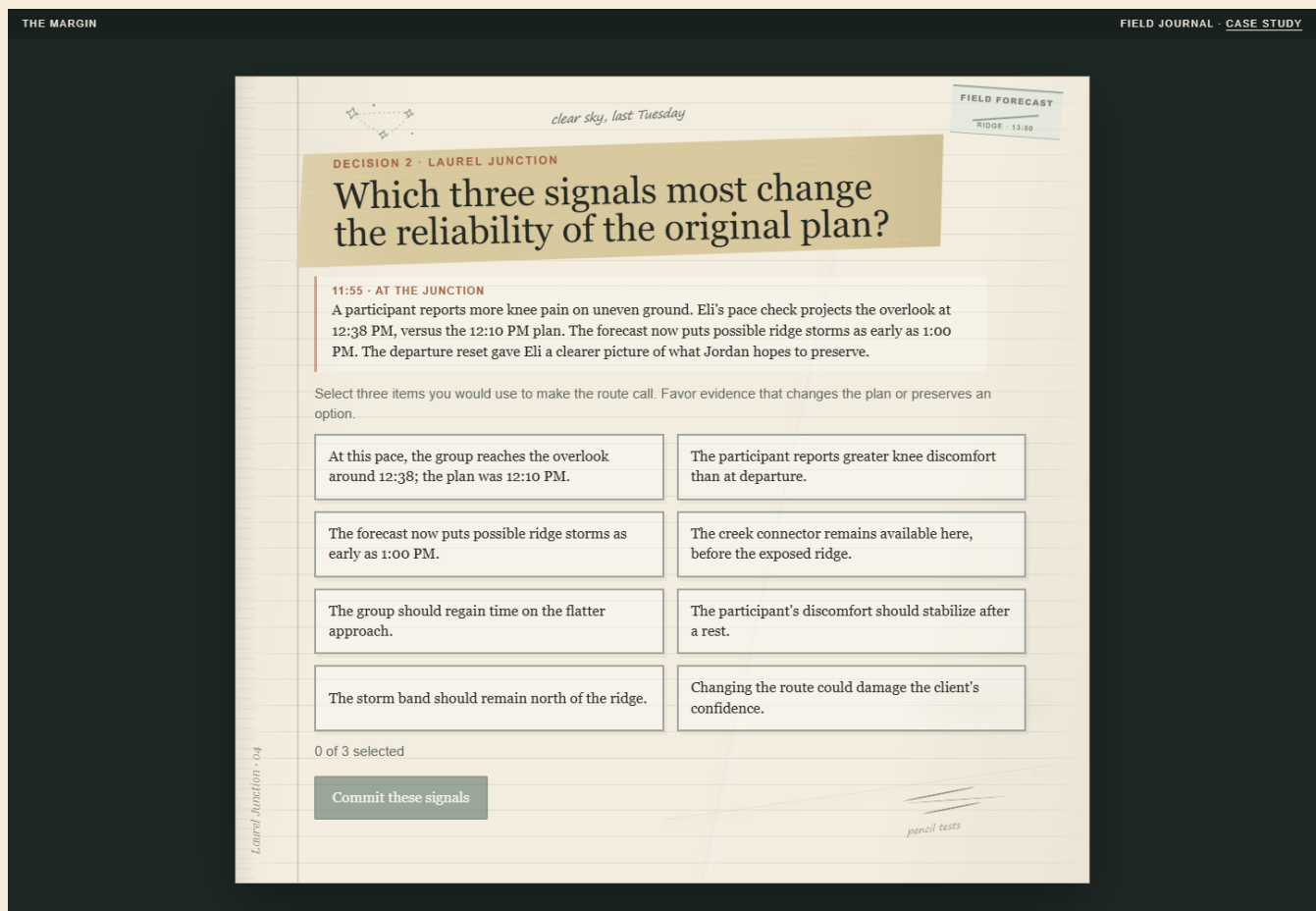
The learning challenge is specific: give people a place to notice interacting signals, revise a plan, and explain their reasoning before momentum makes the decision for them.

Practice calibrated autonomy

Calibrated autonomy means acting independently while recognizing when the situation exceeds your information or authority. Four lenses shape the experience: risk, uncertainty, reversibility, and authority. What could go wrong? Which unknowns matter? Can this choice be undone? Who needs to be involved?

Those lenses support four responses: proceed, pause to investigate, modify, or escalate. They are ways to think, rather than a universal sequence. Escalation can be appropriate; it can also arrive too late or transfer a decision the learner could responsibly own.

A COM-B diagnosis informed the broader concept, considering capability, opportunity, and motivation. The prototype focuses on recognizing changed conditions and communicating a justified response within that larger system.



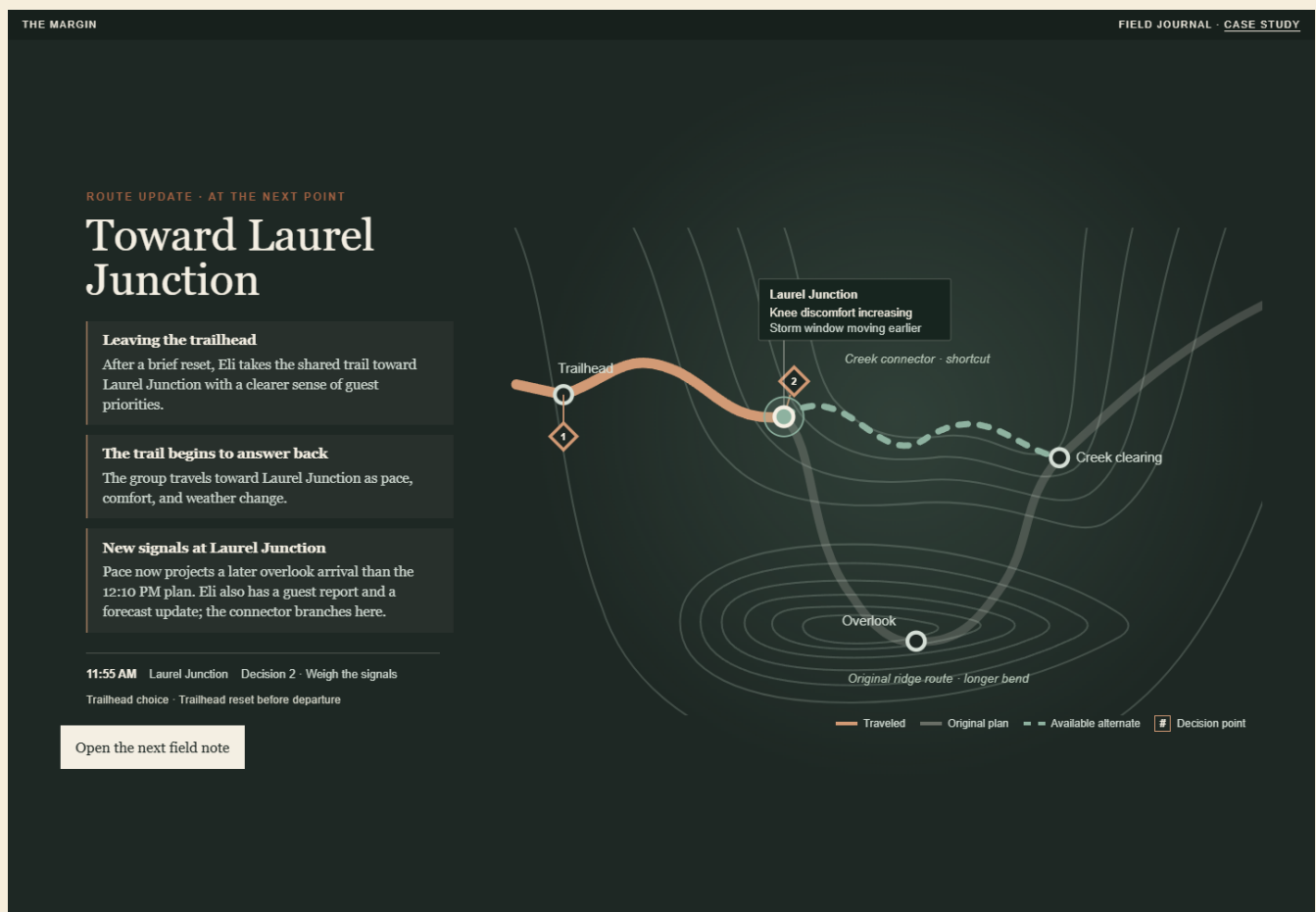
At Laurel Junction, learners distinguish evidence, forecasts, options, and unverified hopes before committing three signals.

02 / EXPERIENCE FLOW

Three decisions, one evolving route

Visitors take the role of Eli Torres, an associate trip leader guiding a ten-person corporate outing on Laurel Ridge. A field journal introduces the trip, while a living map shows movement, available routes, and changing conditions. Information arrives across the journey instead of appearing as a complete briefing.

Three decisions ask learners to prioritize information, identify the signals that most affect the plan, and choose a response with a situation update. The final call changes the route and outcome. Modifying can preserve the group experience; continuing can produce a credible near miss. A trail debrief connects the learner's choices to patterns in awareness, autonomy, and communication.



The living map carries timing, location, changed conditions, and available alternatives between journal pages.

The decision sequence

1. At departure: decide how to respond to a late start. 2. At the junction: identify which signals change the plan. 3. Make the call: recommend a response and build an update to operations and guests.

03 / DESIGN DECISIONS

Judgment becomes visible

1. Make consequences do the teaching

Options differ through timing, ownership, communication, and preserved alternatives. Feedback explains what a choice makes possible or harder. Learners can follow a fragile plan and see its consequences, which gives the debrief something concrete to examine.

2. Make reassessment part of the work

The journal and map separate a decision from the next update. This creates space to orient, observe movement, and reconsider. The state of “the margin” stays implicit: learners infer shrinking room to maneuver from the situation rather than watching a score meter.

3. Preserve the underlying purpose

The corporate organizer needs a meaningful team moment, not necessarily a particular overlook. A shorter creek route can preserve lunch, remarks, inclusion, and schedule. That distinction makes adaptation a professional judgment rather than an admission of failure, while keeping the participant's discomfort from becoming the story's blame point.

The screenshot shows a digital interface for a decision-making exercise. At the top, it says 'THE MARGIN' and 'FIELD JOURNAL CASE STUDY'. The main heading is 'What do you recommend?'. Below this, there are four options: 'Proceed' (Continue toward the overlook after a short rest with a firm turnaround time), 'Modify' (Take the creek connector and identify an alternate lunch location), 'Pause' (Request an updated weather check before selecting a route), and 'Escalate' (Ask the supervisor to select the route). Below these options is a section titled 'Build Eli's update to operations and guests' with three tabs: 'Situation', 'Support', and 'To guests'. The 'Situation' tab is selected, showing a 'READY TO SEND' status and a 'Review your three choices' section. This section contains three boxes: 'SITUATION' (Overlook 25+ minutes late; knee discomfort increasing; ridge storms possible by 1:00), 'SUPPORT' (Confirm receipt and keep the 3:15 pickup; I'll report any return change), and 'TO GUESTS' (Explain the route and what it protects). Each box has an 'Edit' link. Below the 'Review your three choices' section is a 'Back' button and a 'Review before sending' link. At the bottom, there is a 'Commit the decision' button and a 'POST OFFICE' section with a note to 'SEND A NOTE TO ADA' on 'THURSDAY'.

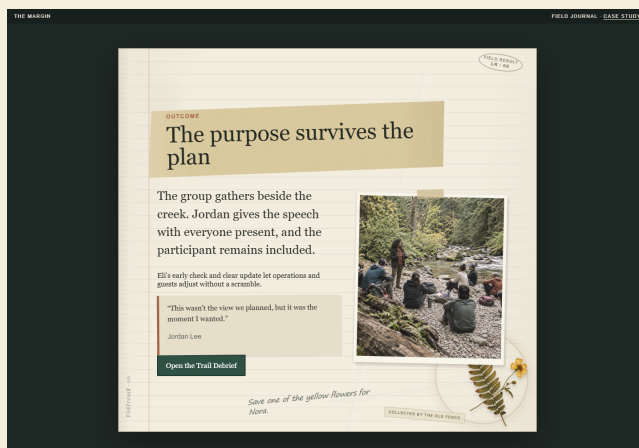
A reviewed recommendation includes the situation, operations support, and guest explanation.

04 / OUTCOME AND REFLECTION

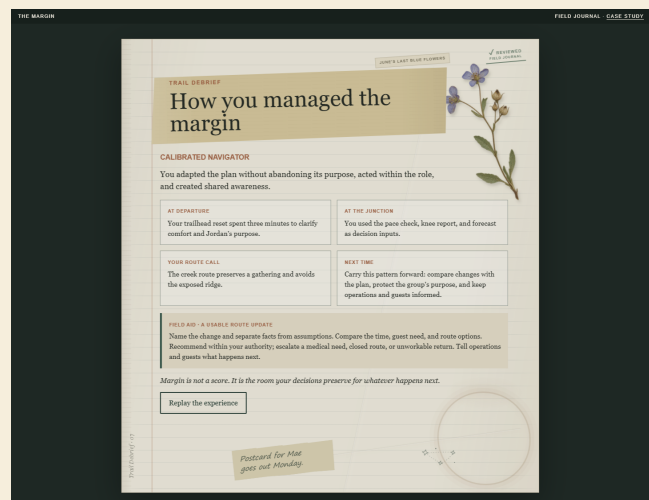
What the prototype demonstrates

The result is a playable prototype with branching outcomes, route transitions, and a decision-specific debrief. It demonstrates the intended practice experience; it does not establish improved workplace performance or reduced incidents. Northstar and the outing are fictional, and the experience uses generated character and environment imagery.

The next evaluation should examine whether learners recognize interacting risks earlier, make proportionate decisions, and communicate useful recommendations in a new scenario. Human-paced usability sessions should also test whether the map and journal help people understand changing conditions without adding unnecessary effort. The central design question remains: can learners explain when their original reasoning stopped holding?



One possible outcome: a changed route preserves the gathering.



The debrief connects earlier choices to a reusable field aid.

Review before claiming impact

A future evaluation should observe first-time visitors, record completion time and decision reasoning, and test the behavior in a new scenario. The intended short experience has not yet been validated through measured learning or transfer results.

Explore the portfolio and playable prototype at mikemunozland.com/work/the-margin.

This is the intended public URL; availability depends on portfolio publication.